

fridayReview

THE HINDU

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**A MODERN-DAY
TROUBADOUR**

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The reluctant superstar

Portrait of an artiste who stayed
on in the spotlight, driven not by ambition
but by necessity, and in the process
changed Hindi film music forever

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Queen of versatility', 'icon of melody'... when the world began describing me with such encomiums, I was thrilled. I never desperately sought them, but slogged to make myself worthy of them. My aspirations were simple, call them stereotypical, if you may – to have a warm, loving home, be a hands-on mother and, above all, cook delicious meals and feed family and friends to their hearts' content (she was known for her expertise in Maharashtrian, Goan and North Western Indian cuisines)," said Asha Bhosle with a laugh when I interviewed her as she turned 80.

In 2020, when I spoke to her ahead of the launch of her YouTube series designed to take ardent listeners on a nostalgic musical journey, she quipped, "*Chote shaher Sangli ki is ladki ko kya maloom tha success aur shauhrat ka matlab?* (how would this girl from the small town of Sangli have known the meaning of success and fame?) I may sound like a worn-out record, but maybe, I would have been happier being just a homemaker. I wasn't ready to face the rough and tumble of a work life."

Asha then quickly added, "I am just saying all this as part of our conversation. No need to put it down in print. Then, people might say I am pretending to be humble."

So, was Asha Bhosle a reluctant superstar? The world usually is not kind to those who it perceives as unambitious. Choosing ordinariness, or living on one's own terms, is often mistaken for lack of drive or as a sign of failure. Most of us choose to fall in line with this definition of a 'good' life. Some, such as the young singer Arijit Singh, dare to defy it. The legendary Asha Bhosle might well have chosen to step away decades ago, had circumstances not forced her to carry on for the sake of her three children, whom she raised single-handedly. Instead, she chose

the next best thing – staying within the system yet leaving on it an unmistakable and enduring stamp. It was certainly a braver and much harder course. It was not a decision taken by the singer Asha, but by an economically vulnerable and resolute woman.

When Asha finally took to playback singing, she encountered what artistes have long spoken of – the Hindi film industry's systemic reluctance to accommodate new talent and its insistence on unquestioning conformity. Despite early training in Indian classical music under her father Dinanath Mangeshkar, a vocalist and theatre artiste, and despite performing with his travelling theatre company, she faced rejection, ridicule and constant comparisons. They reshaped the singer's personality, transforming her from a demure young woman into a rebel intent on breaking conventions and setting her own standards.

Asha's rise to stardom seemed inevitable with a voice that effortlessly traversed genres and emotions. Yet it was not merely innate talent, she worked relentlessly to expand her vocal range and expressive depth, fully aware that carving out a space for herself would not be easy in an industry dominated by stalwarts such as her sister Lata Mangeshkar, Geeta Dutt, Shamshad Begum, Mohammed Rafi, Mukesh and Kishore Kumar who composers of the time preferred to work with.

"Despite my best efforts, acceptance was hard to come by. Sometimes, I would return home dejected, but one look at my children and I would be more determined to return to the studios the very next day. Work would begin at 10 a.m. and go on till late in the evening. I would have only tea and biscuits throughout the day. Even if we missed a single note, we had to record all over again. So, I would keep rehearsing till I got every nuance of the composition and lyric right," she had recalled. She instinctively added, "I know I am



not the only woman or mother with a story of struggle. But I keep sharing mine in the hope that someone out there would hear and not give up."

Behind Asha's dimpled smile and exuberant presence lay the weight of many personal tragedies – the loss of her father in childhood, abandonment by the husband she loved and married, the deaths of her son Hemant and daughter Varsha, and finally the passing of Pancham (RD Burman), with whom she found true love and an extraordinary creative partnership.

In a tribute to the singer, celebrated lyricist Javed Akhtar recalled a beautiful thought Asha once shared with him: "Don't try to search for peace and comfort in human interactions and relationships, you will only be disappointed. Try to find them in your work, by deeply loving whatever you do."

While accepting almost every song that came her way, Asha soon discovered her potential to handle amazingly diverse songs, including cabaret numbers. She had no qualms about singing for vamps on the screen and lent them a unique flavour. Perhaps her personal and professional setbacks enabled Asha to identify with women cast in negative or inconsequential roles. She even developed a deep bond with many of them. Dancer-actor Helen was one such. Visibly moved while paying tribute to Asha, she said, "I am here because she was there."

Having discovered her musical groove, Asha continued to push boundaries. Her oeuvre kept evolving – ghazal, folk, bhavgeet, natya sangeet, thumri and pop. She seemed unstoppable.

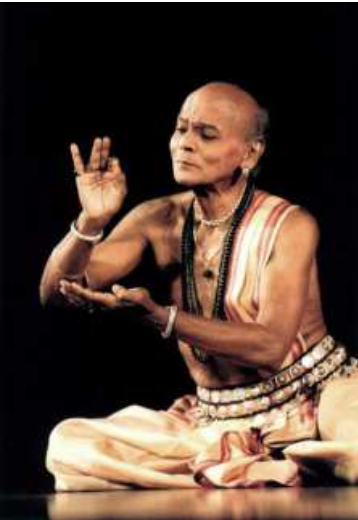
Over the last few years, on the television shows that she appeared in, Asha often said, "*Mein gaate gaate is duniya se jaana chahti hoon* (I want to leave this world while I can still sing). Her last song, 'The Shadowy Light', was released a few weeks ago. A final collaboration with the British band Gorillaz, she felt the song defined her life's journey – with music as the boatman guiding her towards moksha.

'Chal mere maajhi gehra hai paani, mujhe jaana us paar, jahan sukh na ho dukh na ho, jahan jai ho na haar ho.' (Go on boatman, the water is deep, I want to go to the other side of the shore, where there is no happiness or sorrow, no victory or failure).

CULTUREBRIEFS

An ode to Kelubabu

SPIC MACAY, in collaboration with the Aga Khan Trust for Culture, presents Season 2 of the World Dance Day and World Heritage Day celebrations from today until April 19 at the Garden Amphitheatre of Sunder Nursery, New Delhi. The three-day festival will highlight the diversity of India's classical dance heritage. It is also dedicated to Guru Kelucharan Mohapatra to mark his birth centenary. The event line-up, from 6.30 p.m. to 10 p.m.: April 17: Sujata Mohapatra (Odissi), followed by Rama Vaidyanathan (Bharatanatyam). April 18: Sattriya by Anita Sharma, Kuchipudi by Sreelakshmy Govardhanan and Kathak by Monisa Nayak. April 19: Mohiniyattam by Neena Prasad, Manipuri by Manju Elangbam and Kathakali by Thiruvattar B. Jagadeesan.



A day for dance

The 19th World Dance Day Celebrations, curated by Geeta Chandran will be presented by Natya Vriksha on April 25 and 26. Supported by the Ministry of Culture, Government of India, the two-day festival, designed as a confluence of workshops, lecture-demonstrations, panel discussions and performances - will be held at India International Centre, New Delhi. Geeta Chandran, a senior Bharatanatyam dancer and choreographer, and founder-president of Natya Vriksha, says the "festival is a reaffirmation of tradition as a living continuum, with a focus to create a space where classical rigour meets curiosity, where young dancers find direction and where audiences experience dance



as both inheritance and inquiry." The line-up is as follows: April 25, 9.30 a.m., Yangshak movement workshop, facilitated by Imphal-based choreographer and contemporary performing artiste Surjit Nongmeikapam, founder and artistic director of Nachom Arts Foundation.



Rooted in Manipuri traditions, the workshop explores spine, breath, impulse, weight shifting and geometries, drawing from martial arts Thang-Ta and traditional dance. At 4 p.m. Sucheta Bhide-Chapekar will present 'Pravahita', accompanied by Arundhati Patwardhan and Sagarika Patwardhan, blending Bharatanatyam with Hindustani music through her innovative Nritya-Ganga. This will be followed by Yuva Nritya Utsav at 6.30 p.m. with Bharatanatyam by Karuna Sagari from Chennai and Kathak by Ameera



Patankar from Pune at 7.45 p.m. April 26 begins with the Yangshak Movement Workshop at 9.30 a.m., led by Surjit Nongmeikapam; followed by a panel discussion (4 p.m.) titled - AI & Dance: Challenges and Opportunities - led by Anita Ratnam with Madhu Nataraj, director of STEM Dance Kampni, Bengaluru, as a keynote speaker. This will be followed by Yuva Nritya Utsav featuring Odissi by Vrinda Chadha (New Delhi) at 6.30 p.m., and Kuchipudi by Avijit Das from Bengaluru at 7.45 p.m.

Suganthy Krishnamachari

One thousand years ago (1023-1024 CE), Chola king Rajendra I's army marched to the Gangetic plains, defeating many kings on the way, collected water from the Ganga, and poured it into Chola Gangam, the lake Rajendra built in his capital, Gangaikondacholapuram. What if someone tried to follow the Chola trail now? Ramesh Vangipuram, an IT professional, history researcher and author decided to do precisely that. Because the Cholas did not leave behind any artefacts in the regions they passed through, Ramesh had to rely on information found in the Thirumalai inscription, which gives the sequential order of the places on the Chola route. He had to fix the geographical boundaries of the kingdoms the army crossed. He drew up maps, which were validated by Odiyan scholar Kornel Das. "Rajendra did not lead his army to the Ganga, but stayed back in Andhra," clarifies Ramesh.

Ramesh travelled by bus, train and cab to take the Chola route. But occasionally, he had to deviate because of practical difficulties such as inhospitable terrains. Of the two possible routes from Rajahmundry to Sakkarakottam (present day Chitrakoot in Chattisgarh), Ramesh believed the Cholas would have taken the route



In the footsteps of an empire

Ahead of World Heritage Day, meet Ramesh Vangipuram, who embarked on a journey to retrace the Chola army's march to the Gangetic plains

through Vengi, because they had marital ties with the Eastern Chalukyas who ruled Vengi. Additionally, feudatories of Sakkarakottam that were on this route could be defeated. Masunidesam and Maduramandalam were provinces under

Sakkarakottam. Masunidesam is described in the Thirumalai inscription as an area lush with fields, and this region (the Indravati-Kolab river basin) is even today referred to as the granary of Odisha. Kornel identified Maduramandalam as present-day Mudulipada on

A slice of history (Clockwise from left) The Bhujang Valley (Candi) Shiva temple; Ramesh Vangipuram; and Varendra (Maldah) on the Northern bank of the river Ganga. Photos courtesy: Ramesh Vangipuram.

the Bondoni hills in Odisha. "Mudulipada could be a corruption of Mudirpada mentioned in the inscription," says Ramesh, who first went to Masunidesam and from there to Maduramandalam, whereas the Cholas would have gone to Maduramandalam first. He then reached Chitrakoot near Jagdalpur. However, there is nothing to show where the Sakkarakottam battle took place.

Namanikkonam (Niyamagiri and Kona in Odisha), with its dense groves, matched the description in the inscription to a 't'. Kosala Nadu is described in the inscription as a 'good country'. What warranted this praise? During his visit to Sonepur (once the capital of Kosala Nadu), Ramesh found that the town had 108 temples, for a population of just 17,000. It is called the Varanasi of the South and is at the confluence of three rivers. "Maybe its sacredness prompted the Cholas to refer to Kosala as righteous," says Ramesh.

Because the Cholas saw Kosala in a positive light, they probably did not attack it. Both Kosala Nadu and Odda Vishaya were ruled by the Somavanshis, during

Rajendra's time. Odda Vishaya is the present day Dhenkanal district in Odisha (vishaya- district).

The inscription says Dandabhuthi, the next place where the Cholas laid their footprints, had gardens where bees abounded. "Panskura in East Midnapore district is the flower hub of Bengal, supplying 70 per cent of the state's requirement of flowers during Durga puja. As one travels by train, one can see nurseries with many flowering plants here. So, this region must have been Dandabhuthi. "The political divisions of Bengal and Bangladesh were Varendra, Radha, Vangala Desa and Samatata. Radha was further divided into Uttara Ladam and Thakkana Ladam. The Thirumalai inscription gives the sequence of the march as Dandabhuthi, Thakkana Ladam, Vangala Desam and Uttara Ladam," explains Ramesh. Having defeated Ranapura, king of Thakkana Ladam, the Cholas could have collected water from the Ganges there, or they could have gone to Uttara Ladam and done so. Why did they go to Vangala Desam? "They would have wanted to gather information about ships visiting the region, to prepare for Rajendra's maritime expedition against the Srivijaya kingdom."

The capital of Vangala Desam was near Dhaka, in Bangladesh. From Vangala Desam, the Cholas moved to Uttara Ladam, which consists of the modern districts of

Murshidabad, Birbhum, some parts of Santal Parkanas and Jharkand. Uttara Ladam was ruled by the Pala dynasty, which once had control over a large part of Bihar, Bengal and Bangladesh. But by the 10th century, the kingdom had shrunk, and it was Mahipala I (988 CE- 1036 CE), who restored a large part of the kingdom, and he was ruling over Uttara Ladam, when the Chola army defeated him. But the legend of Mahipala lives on in North Bengal. When Ramesh visited the area, he was shown a tank built by Mahipala, which is still called Mahipal Dighi. "The Chola army must have collected water from the Ganga in Uttara Ladam, or further up in Varendra, on the Northern side of the Ganga", says Ramesh, who has recorded details of the path the Cholas took in a book titled *Warpath*.



Ramesh travelled by bus, train and cab to take the Chola route. But occasionally, he had to deviate because of practical difficulties such as inhospitable terrains.

Because Rajendra is praised as one who conquered Purvadesam (comprising some regions of Odisha), Ramesh visited the area, although it was not on the Gangetic route of the Cholas. "Kornel Das says that a Chola influence can be seen here. The Sodha Porajas, who live here, are the only tribe to celebrate Bhogi. There is a place here called Tamili. The ancient name of Anchalagumma was Ko Chola gumma."

Ramesh is now preparing to travel the route the Cholas took during their Srivijaya expedition. He made a preliminary visit to Malaysia (old name Kadaram), and met historian Selvakumar. The latter said that Pengkalen Bhujang was probably the point of disembarkation of the Cholas and that from there they would have gone to Bhujang Valley. The museum at the foot of the hills in Bhujang valley, has artefacts from Raja Raja's and Rajendra's time. There are three Shiva temples on the hill, at different levels. Above the top most temple are two waterfalls, and beyond this, Selvakumar pointed to some remnants of an old settlement. "We could not cross the waterfalls, because it had rained just then. But it was Selvakumar's guess that the Srivijaya fort mentioned by Rajendra must have been on top of the hill, beyond the waterfalls", says Ramesh.



CULTURE BRIEFS

Special concerts

The Music Academy presents Bhavana Iyer's vocal concert today at 6 p.m. She will be accompanied by S. Subhashree (violin) and Srivanchiam R. Sriram (mridangam). Organised as part of Swati Tirunal day, the performance to take place at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall, is held under the endowment instituted by M/s. Arun Fabricators. Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha has organised Rithvik Raja's vocal concert on April 23, 6.30 p.m. as part of the Syama Sastri day celebrations. R.K. Shriram Kumar (violin), J. Vaidhyanathan (mridangam) and V. Anirudh Athreya (kanjira) will accompany. Venue: Vani Mahal, T. Nagar.



Debut

Aashritha Sanjay, disciple of Ramya Rajeshkumar, will present her Bharatanatyam arangetram on April 20, 6.30 p.m., at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar.

Tirumurai series

As part Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha's Panniru Tirumarai renditions from today till April 19 at Vani Mahal, odhuvars will present Tirumurai each evening. Schedule: Today, 5 p.m.: Manikavasakan and 7 p.m.: Sargurunathan. April 18, 5 p.m.: Kudandhai Lakshmanan and 7 p.m.: Tamilarasu and Arun Karthik. April 19, 5 p.m.: Balachandran and 7 p.m.: Tiruttani Swaminathan.

Bani sets the musical bar

The timelessness of Ariyakudi Ramanuja Iyengar's concert paddhathi and K.V. Narayanaswamy's exemplary artistry

N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

In commemoration of the legendary musician K.V. Narayanaswamy's Remembrance Day, the Sri Ariyakkudi & Sri K.V. Narayanaswamy Memorial Trust organised a series of concerts. Pattabhirama Pandit presented a kutcheri at Arkay Convention Centre, accompanied by Mullaivasal Chandramouli on the violin, B. Ganapathyram on the mridangam and Trichy Murali on the ghatam. Despite some vocal strain, Pattabhirama steered the concert with an engaging repertoire, including several compositions that evoked memories of KVN. Adhering to the traditional practice of hinting at the main raga through the opening varnam, he began with Veenai Kuppaiyer's classic 'Sami ninne', taught to almost every student initiated into the world of varnams.

The Tiruppavai suite, as tuned by Ariyakudi Ramanuja Iyengar, consists of masterful compositions that deserve a place on the concert stage far beyond the ritualistic singing of



Notes of reverence Pattabhirama Pandit accompanied by Mullaivasal Chandramouli (violin), B. Ganapathyram (mridangam) and Trichy Murali (ghatam). PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Margazhi. Pattabhirama chose to present the original version of 'Nayakanai nindra' in Darbar, staying true to Ariyakudi's initial vision and KVN's steadfast adherence to patantaram. While this piece has largely transformed into the sprightly Mohanam version commonly heard today, the choice of Darbar provided a regal and apt moment in the concert's progression. Contextually, since 'Nayakanai' involves the gopis pleading with the guardians of the palace gate, the choice of Darbar (which means 'court')

creates a union of tune and meaning, sounding like a formal petition at a king's court.

In an alapana that launched brightly into the upper octave, the vocalist explored Vachaspati in exhaustive detail. This was followed by Papanasam Sivan's 'Paratpara parameshwara,' with niraval and kalpanaswaras at the phrase 'Ari ayanum.' The raga was thoroughly mined during the manodharma sections; notably, the final kalpanaswara followed a clever staircase structure, incrementally

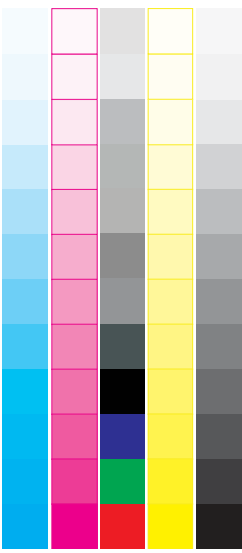
incorporating key swaras into the refrain before concluding in a crisp pattern. Chandramouli on the violin met the challenge admirably, turning the kalpanaswaras into a spirited, almost conversational exchange.

Shifting gears to the soulful 'Mayamma' in Ahiri and 'Brova bhaarama,' Pattabhirama then offered inventive kalpanaswaras in Bahudari. The recital later featured 'Dattatreya trimurti roopa,' a bhajan by Ganapathy Sacchidananda Swami, elegantly retuned in Ranjani by KVN and Padma Narayanaswamy.

While the melodic and rhythmic framework of their setting tempts a performer to add flourishes, the inherent bhava of the piece resists excessive ornamentation – drawing the listener back to the profound simplicity of KVN's original rendition. It serves as a reminder that in the KVN school, the 'shuddham' (purity) of the note often carries more weight than the complexity of the gamaka. While KVN often culminated the piece with an electrifying niraval at 'Sahyadri vasa,' Pattabhirama bypassed it to save the momentum for the main raga that followed.

The centrepiece of the evening was Sankarabharanam. The alapana took some time to settle, but once it found its footing, it unfurled through clear akarams and a few well-placed brigas. Pattabhirama chose Swati Tirunal's 'Devi jagajjanani,' from the Navaratri Mandapam set. The niraval at the anupallavi line, 'Deva makutamani dedipyamanapade', was handled with care and the raga bhava was maintained even in the fast portions. The subsequent kalpanaswaras felt like a natural dialogue between

the vocalist and the violinist, staying true to the unhurried sarvalaghu patterns associated with the KVN school. A neat korvai concluded the swara segment, providing a clean transition into the tani avartanam. Throughout the kutcheri, Ganapathyram on the mridangam exhibited keen enthusiasm and a pre-emptive sense of awareness. Trichy Murali on the ghatam lent depth to the rhythmic sections, providing a crisp tonal contrast to the mridangam. The recital concluded with 'Krishna nee begane' and a thillana in Kanada.



ஆதரவற்றோருக்கு அன்னமிடும் மதுரையின் அட்சயப்பாத்திரம் | 365 பேரில் நீங்களும் ஒருவராக உதவலாமே!



அற்றார் அழிபசி தீர்த்தல் அஃதொருவன் பெற்றான் பொருள்வைப் புழி

“பட்டினி எனச் சொல்லி வந்தவரின் பசியைத் தீர்ப்பது வீண் போகாது. அதுவே, தான் தேடிய செல்வம் பிற்காலத்தில் உதவ சேமித்து வைக்கக்கூடிய உண்மையான சொத்தாகும்” என்கிறார் திருவள்ளுவர். நவரத்தினங்களில் உயர்ந்தது மாணிக்கம், உலோகங்களில் உயர்ந்தது தங்கம். இவற்றை தானமாகக் கொடுப்பது பற்றி எல்லாம் நம் முன்னோர் சிலாகித்துச் சொல்லவில்லை. அன்னதானத்தை பற்றித்தான் அவ்வளவு பெருமையாகச் சொல்லி இருக்கிறார்கள்.

மகாபாரதத்தில் கர்ணன், தனது இறுதிக் காலத்தில் சொர்க்கம் சென்ற போது, அன்னதானம் நடந்த இடத்தை கைகாட்டிய விரலை வாயில் வைத்தபோதுதான் அவனது பசி அடங்கியது. அவன் செய்த மற்ற தானங்கள் எதுவும் அவனுக்குப் பயன் தரவில்லை. ஆக, நம் முன்னோர்கள் ஒன்றும் சும்மா சொல்லிச் செல்லவில்லை, **“தானங்களில் சிறந்தது அன்னதானம்”** என்று..!

“குலதெய்வத்தின் அருள் கிடைக்கும், அடுத்த ஏழேழு தலைமுறைக்கும் நன்மைகள் கிடைத்து, சந்ததிகளும் பிள்ளைகளும் விருத்தி அடைவார்கள்!” என முன்னோர்கள் சொல்லிச் சென்றது அன்னதானத்தில் மகிமையையே எடுத்துக்காட்டுகிறது. நாளொன்றுக்கு எவ்வளவோ செலவு செய்கிறோம். சம்பாதித்து தனக்கான உணவுத் தேவையைக் கூடப் பூர்த்தி செய்ய இயலாத, ஆதரவற்ற வறியோரும், முதியோரும் இன்னும் இப்புவலகில் இருக்கத்தான் செய்கிறார்கள். அவர்களுக்கு உதவி செய்யும் வாய்ப்பை கருணையான இறைவன் நமக்கு அருளி இருக்கிறான்.



தங்களுக்கு தினமும் யாருக்கேனும் அன்னதானம் செய்யலாம்! ஆனால் அதை எவ்வழியில் செய்வது? என்ற எண்ணம் இருக்கும்.

வேலைப்பளு காரணமாகவும் அதனைச் செய்ய இயலாத சூழல் இருக்கலாம். இந்த அரிய வாய்ப்பினையும் இறைவன் கொடுத்த நல்வாய்ப்பாகக் கருதி, பயன்படுத்திக் கொள்ளுங்கள் என அன்போடு வேண்டுகிறோம்!



இந்தப் பணியினை கடந்த 6 ஆண்டுகளாகத் தொடர்ச்சியாகச் செய்து வரும் **மதுரையின் அட்சய பாத்திரம் டிரஸ்டுன்** இணைந்து, இல்லாதவருக்கு உணவு வழங்குங்கள். உணவு சமைத்து, அதனை டப்பாக்களில் அடைத்து, அவர்களது இருப்பிடம் கொண்டு சேர்க்கும் வரை... **ஒரு நாளுக்கு ஒருவருக்கு மதிய உணவுக்கான செலவு ரூ.40 ஆகிறது.** கடந்த ஆறு ஆண்டுகளுக்கும் மேலாக, கருணை உள்ளம் கொண்ட கொடையாளர்களின் உதவியோடு மட்டுமே இது சாத்தியமாகி வருகிறது. அதே சமயம் ஒவ்வொரு மாதமும் கொடையாளர்களை தேடி பிடிப்பதும் சற்று சிரமமாக இருக்கிறது.

365 நாளுக்கும் ஒரு நற்கொடையாளர் என்ற வீதத்தில் உங்களின் உதவியை எதிர்நோக்கி காத்திருக்கிறோம்..! இதில், பங்கேற்று தினமும் ஒருவருக்கான செலவான, ரூ. 40 வீதம் 300 பேருக்கு ஒரு நாளைக்கு ரூ. 12,000 என கொடுத்து பங்கேற்கலாம். இதனை Cheque, M.O. மற்றும் G-Pay மூலம் அனுப்பலாம். அனுப்பிய விவரத்தை வாட்ஸ்ஆப் மூலம் தெரிவிக்க வேண்டுகிறோம்.

அரிய வாய்ப்பு இது! நமக்கு உதவலாம் என்ற எண்ணம் இருந்தாலும் அதை செயல்படுத்துவதில், நடைமுறை சிக்கல்கள் நிறையவே இருக்கும். எங்களோடு இணைந்து தினமும் ஒருவரின் வயிற்றுப் பசியை ஆற்றும் அறப்பணியைக் கைகோர்த்து செய்திட அன்புடன் வேண்டுகிறோம்..! மேற்கண்டபடி தர இயலாவிட்டால் தாங்கள் விரும்பியபடி எவ்வாறேனும், தங்கள் வசதிக்கு ஏற்ப தேர்ந்தெடுத்துக் கொள்ளலாம்.

இந்த நல்ல அரிய வாய்ப்பினை பயன்படுத்திக் கொண்டு, தயவு செய்து அன்னதானம் செய்து தங்களது சந்ததிகளை விருத்தி பெற செய்வதோடு, முன்னோர் பாவங்கள் ஏதேனும் இருந்தாலும் நிவர்த்தி பெற்று புண்ணியத்தை தேடி கொள்ளுங்கள். தாங்கள் அளிக்கும் நன்கொடைகளுக்கு 80% வருவாய் வரிவிலக்கு உண்டு.

வறியவர்களுக்கு உணவு வழங்குவது பித்ருகளுக்கு திதி கொடுத்த புண்ணியம் கிடைக்கும்

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On a different stage From Kahanibaaz sessions.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



career and personal ups and downs. The show, which has already been staged in several Indian cities, will be presented on May 9 at Arena - The Art Experience, Chennai and May 10 at Samarathanam Auditorium, Bengaluru. During a phone interview, the multifaceted artiste speaks about his latest passion – storytelling.

Ashish calls it therapeutic because in times marked with anger and division, he wants to remind audiences of the gentleness within us all – memories, desires and joys that make life meaningful. His shows move people to laughter,

tears and reflection, he says. “They normalise defeat, celebrate resilience and remind audiences that setbacks are not anomalies but part of the journey,” says Ashish, who also adds that his stories resonate across age, gender and



When I act, I inhabit the character's world. But when I narrate, I bare my own experiences and emotions

ASHISH VIDYARTHI

geography. “People tell me it feels as if I am talking about their life.” This connection, he says, is special. Kahanibaaz is only one facet of his creative persona. Two years ago, “almost on a lark”, Ashish stepped into the world of stand-up comedy. He blends humour with storytelling, poking fun at life’s absurdities and himself.

He also has his food and travel vlogs, which have earned him a devoted following online. From Kolkata’s biryani joints to hidden gems in Palakkad, Ashish explores India’s culinary landscape with an infectious enthusiasm. For him, food is not just about taste – it is about people, culture, and appreciation. He celebrates the simple, authentic everyday menus on the street and in homes. “When we can appreciate what is around us, our life becomes amazing,” he says.

Ashish encourages people to explore facets of themselves beyond their profession. “By 40, many feel trapped and by 50, it becomes a resignation. But life is abundant, it allows us different opportunities. It is up to us if we want to explore them. Rather than waiting to become a millionaire, start enjoying life as it unfolds,” says the actor, who is also a motivational speaker.

He holds every place his career has taken him to close to his heart. “The audience everywhere accepted me as one of theirs.” His memories of these cities find their way into his stories, and with Kahanibaaz now boasting “over 225 stories” that he “rotates across shows”.

Despite this, Ashish remains committed to acting too. He bristles at being offered “special roles” and insists on central, stellar parts. “I have decided that I am not giving myself any more raw deals. We all are waiting for amazing things to happen. But what you do while you are waiting will determine your life.”

CALENDAR

The stage is set

The annual Kodai Nataka Vizha, hosted by Kartik Fine Arts is back with a fresh line-up of plays for lovers of Tamil theatre.

This year marks the 35th edition of KFA's summer drama festival. It will be inaugurated by its president S.N. Srikanth on April 22, 6.30 p.m. at Narada Gana Sabha main hall. Twelve new plays will be staged at two different venues – April 22 to 30 at Sathguru Gnanananda Hall and May 1 to 3 at TAG Mylapore Fine Arts Club. Show time: 7 p.m.

Awards and rolling trophies will be given under various categories on June 1. Prizes for best reviews will also be given on that day at Mylapore Fine Arts Club auditorium.

The festival, which has served as a platform for both amateur and established theatre groups to stage their productions, has always been a non-ticketed event, with an aim to draw audiences. Following is the list of plays to be staged.

The curtains go up with Sathya Sai Creations' *Yamini En Kanmani* on April 22 at 7 p.m.

Other plays to be staged are: April 23: Brahma Fine Arts' *Maya Sangili*. April 24: JC Creations' *Madhil Mel Poonalgal*. April 25: Legally Yours' *Kudambadang*. April 26: S. Sruuthi's Naatyaa Nadha Nataka Sangamam's *Kandhan Karunai*. April 27: PMG Mayurapriya's *Kallabirammam*. April 28: Prasidhi Creations' *Yagavarayinum*. April 29: Theatrix Stage Crafters' *Mazhivil Ore Iravu*. April 30: Koothapiran Navabharath Theatres' *Veera*. May 1: Ajay Entertainers' *Kannamma*. May 2: Theatre Marina's *Seyyadha Kolai*.

The annual festival concludes with Dummies Drama's new play *Thanim Al* on May 3.

Earth Day soundscapes



Soumik Datta's latest project, 'Melodies in Slow Motion', will premiere at Mumbai's GSA Warehouse on April 22, coinciding with Earth Day (April 22) 2026. The show will have a rerun on April 23, at the same venue, marking the finale of his seven-month India tour. It brings

together music, science and visual art in a unique exploration of the planet's fragility.

Soumik, a sarodist and sound artiste, has long been associated with causes. With 'Melodies in Slow Motion', he turns ecological concepts into immersive soundscapes. The work, commissioned by the British Council India and co-produced with GSA, transforms field recordings into what Soumik calls “ear cinema.”

He has collaborated with percussionist Sumesh Narayanan, violinist Sayee Rakshith, and tabla player Debjit Patitundi, integrating recordings of insect choirs and intertidal zones captured by Rahul Nandkarni.

The ensemble's music pulses with circadian rhythms, tracing the microtonal shifts of birds in murmuration and the dance of honeybees. It also includes a visual collage -- of sketches by children from Pratham Creativity Clubs that animate geometric patterns of nature -- adding a layer of imagination and interconnectedness. Over 100 students participated in workshops, exploring forests and parks, their art now woven into the performance.

Bharatanatyam solo

Natyarangam will present the Bharatanatyam performances of Tony Pius (6 p.m.) followed by Akhila Balasubramaniam (7.30 p.m.). on April 18 at its mini hall.



Small Habits Big Impact

When couples begin thinking about fertility, they often focus on the big factors—age, medical conditions, or genetics. While these certainly matter, fertility is also influenced by “micro habits” that may seem harmless in isolation, but can influence hormonal balance, sperm quality, ovulation, sleep quality, and metabolic health. Here are 5 such habits worth paying attention to.

1. Eating More Carbs
A diet dominated by refined carbohydrates can contribute to blood sugar spikes and insulin resistance. Over time, this may affect ovulation in women and sperm health in men. Balanced meals that prioritize protein, vegetables, fruits, and healthy fats

help stabilize blood sugar and support hormone production. Ensure that half your plate contains vegetables or fruits, with protein included.

2. Doom Scrolling in Bed
Scrolling through news or social media late into the night to unwind? Blue light exposure delays melatonin production, and stimulating content keeps the brain alert when it should be preparing for rest. Poor sleep affects cortisol levels and reproductive hormones, which can interfere with ovulation cycles and testosterone production. Create a “phone-free” buffer of 30–60 minutes before bedtime for better sleep.

3. Wearing Tight Underwear
For men in particular, wearing tight underwear made from synthetic materials can increase heat around the groin. Elevated testicular temperature has been associated with reduced sperm count and motility. Switching to breathable fabrics such as cotton and avoiding excessively tight clothing can help maintain optimal conditions for sperm production.

4. Not Counting All Drinks or Smokes in a Week
“Just one” drink or cigarette may not

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Dr. K.S. Kavitha Gautham,
MBBS, MS (OG)
Managing Director,
BloomLife Hospital Pvt. Ltd.

seem significant, but they add up across the week. Both alcohol and smoking can negatively affect egg quality, sperm count, and hormone balance. Being honest about total weekly consumption is the first step toward reducing intake.

5. Thinking Walking Is the Only Exercise You Need
Walking is definitely beneficial for overall health, but walking alone may not provide the full range of metabolic and hormonal benefits needed for optimal reproductive health. Strength training and moderate-intensity exercise help improve insulin sensitivity, support hormone regulation, and maintain healthy body composition—all of which influence fertility.

Our **Fertility Friday** initiative approaches fertility and pregnancy from an individualised, holistic perspective. To know more, call +91-72999 11107.